

Caring for a Parent with Arthritis: Practical Tips

Practical NHS-backed advice on caring for a parent with arthritis practical tips.

By **Living With Arthritis UK** · Reviewed by **Louis Maxwell** (HCPC Registered Physiotherapist) · 2026-07-24 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

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Quick Answer: The most effective carer support combines practical home adaptations, gentle encouragement of exercise, medication management help, and emotional presence — while protecting your own wellbeing. Small daily adjustments make a big difference without removing your parent's independence.

Watching a parent struggle with arthritis pain is difficult. This guide offers practical, evidence-based tips for family carers of a parent with any type of arthritis.

Understand Their Specific Condition

Osteoarthritis, rheumatoid arthritis, gout, and psoriatic arthritis each affect the body differently and require different approaches. Ask their rheumatologist or GP what the condition means day-to-day, what to watch for, and how you can best help.

Home Adaptations That Help



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An NHS occupational therapy assessment (free, via GP referral) will identify the most important changes. Common adaptations include grab rails, raised toilet seats, lever taps, easy-grip utensils, and good lighting to reduce fall risk.

Low-Cost Adaptations to Do Now

- Lever door handles instead of round knobs
- Grip aids and jar openers in the kitchen
- Non-slip mats in bathroom and kitchen
- A perching stool for standing tasks
- Medications pre-sorted in a weekly dosette box

Supporting Movement and Exercise

Regular gentle exercise is one of the most effective treatments for arthritis per NICE guidelines. Encourage and accompany your parent to walking groups, hydrotherapy, or chair exercise classes rather than suggesting complete rest. Inactivity worsens stiffness and pain over time.

Emotional Support



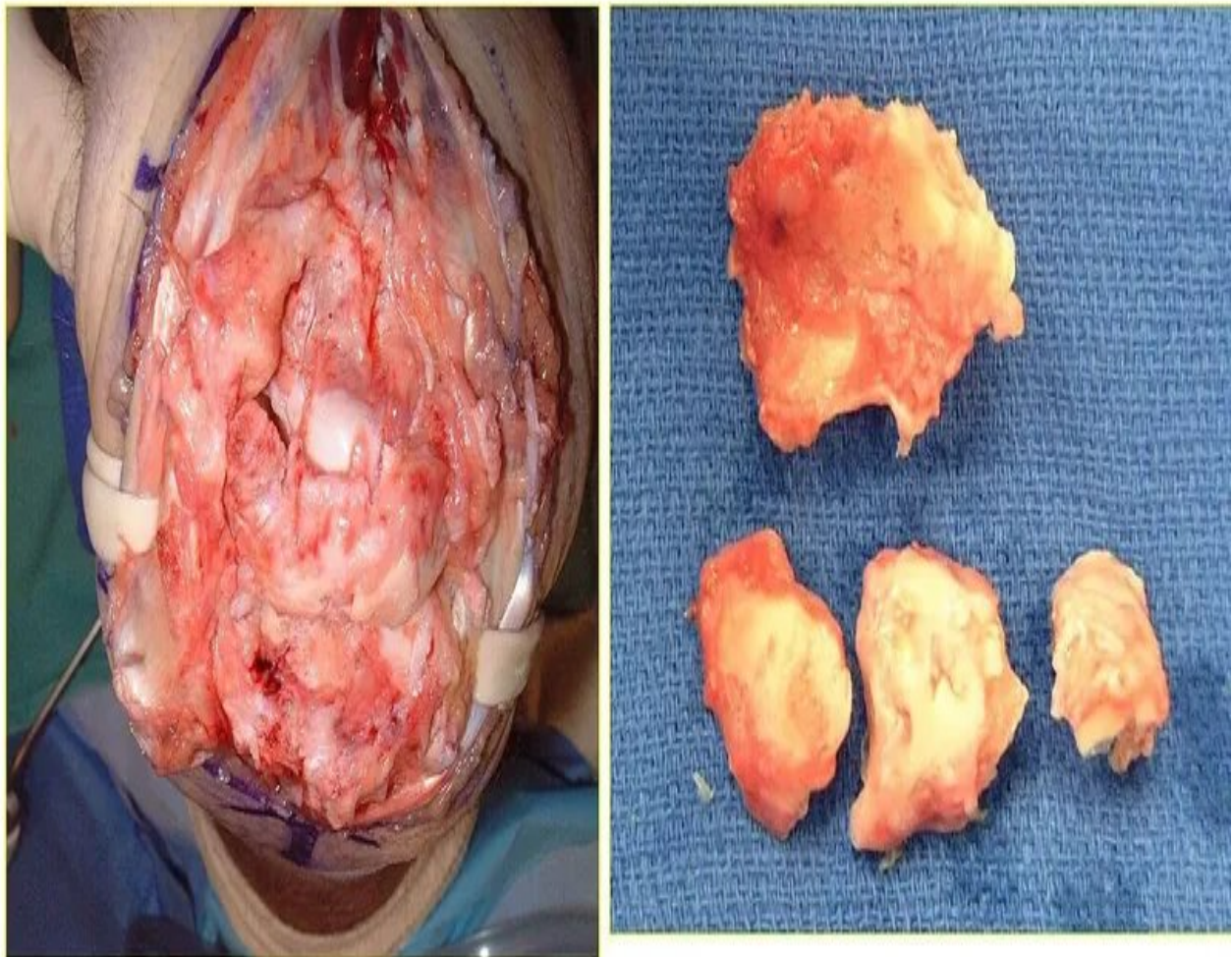
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Arthritis is associated with significantly higher rates of depression and anxiety. Listen without minimising. Acknowledge that the pain is real and that adapting takes time. Encouraging social connection — including support groups — is as important as physical care.

Looking After Yourself

Register with your GP as a carer. Contact Carers UK (0808 808 7777) for free advice on Carer's Allowance and respite care. Carer fatigue is a recognised health risk — your own wellbeing matters too.

Q&A;



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Question: How do I help without taking away their independence? **Short answer:** Always ask before helping. Focus on genuinely difficult tasks like jars or buttons while stepping back from what they can still do safely.

Question: Can I get financial support as a carer? **Short answer:** Possibly. If you provide 35+ hours of care weekly you may qualify for Carer's Allowance. Contact Citizens Advice for a free benefits check.

Question: What should I do during an arthritis flare? **Short answer:** Prioritise rest, ensure medications are taken, use prescribed heat or cold therapy, and contact the GP or rheumatology helpline if the flare is severe or unusually prolonged.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk